



» T20 WC DIARY

Game time: As Colombo braces for another World Cup showdown between India and Pakistan, a steady stream of fans heads towards the R. Premadasa Stadium. ANISH PATHIYIL

A CITY SPLIT BY CRICKET

Our reporters capture the **moments between deliveries:** the streets, the chants, the cramped press boxes and the city that lives the game long before the first ball.

It may no longer be the most exciting contest. It isn't even a fair fight in terms of skill. Yet an India versus Pakistan World Cup clash always occupies a pedestal of its own. Yes, the head-to-head record has been skewed, but the 2021 T20 World Cup loss by 10 wickets quickly sweeps to the forefront of memory, serving as a timely reminder. Add to that the hullabaloo and turncoating before this game was played. All of it only fuelled the hype.

The Diary landed in Colombo on the morning of the match, eager to soak in what this rivalry has to offer. On a Sunday, the roads in Colombo's city centre looked like those in a hartal-hit Kerala town. But a tuk-tuk ride to Khetarama painted an entirely different picture. The promenade towards the R. Premadasa Stadium was buzzing. Indian blue, Pakistani green, and even Sri Lankan blue flooded the street.

"India will win. *Bharat Mata ki jai!*" shouted one local jersey seller. A sound business idea in the current hyper-nationalistic climate, it must be said.

The Diary took out his weapon of choice, a selfie stick, to capture some of the fanfare ahead of the game. The crowd was a proper mix. Middle-aged men reliving dreams they had once missed. A father trying to instil a love for the game in his children. Young adults taking their parents to what was probably their first live match.

There was competitive chanting too. Cries of "Pakistan Zindabad" were quickly drowned out by roars of "India, India!" A few rogue elements tried to incite trouble by hurling abuses, but they were few and far between. One such halfwit came charging towards the Diary's phone camera, hoping for his 10 seconds of fame. Little did he know the camera wasn't even recording.

Anish Pathiyil

LIKE FATHER, LIKE SON

On February 10 at the Arun Jaitley Stadium, Bas de Leede won the Player-of-the-Match award with an unbeaten 72 against Namibia in the Netherlands' only win of the 2026 T20 World Cup. Featuring in his fourth T20 World Cup, the 26-year-old continues to build on the cricketing legacy of his illustrious father, Tim de Leede, who represented the Dutch in three ODI World Cups.

Tim's moment in the sun came against India at the 2003 Cricket World Cup, when he claimed four wickets to be adjudged Player of the Match, even though his team went on to lose that fixture. His connection with India stretches further back, having begun his ODI career at the 1996 Cricket World Cup. Bas, too, featured in the 2023 ODI World Cup in India.

Naturally, the question arises: how often does Bas turn to his father for guidance?

"Not too much, to be honest. He played in an era when T20 cricket wasn't a massive thing yet. It's more about him showing support to me rather than trying to get involved with a lot of tips," Bas said.

Eight days later, at the same venue, South African all-rounder Corbin Bosch bagged the Player-of-the-Match honour against the UAE with figures of 4-0-12-3. Featuring in a World Cup for the first time, he is also following in the footsteps of his father. Tertius Bosch represented South Africa in the 1992 Cricket World Cup. The former speedster died in 2000 at the age of 33.

Asked what it felt like to emulate his father, Corbin reflected: "He was an incredible man, and I've aspired to be the human being that he was. I think a lot of people speak about his character, so that's more what drives me. I'm trying to create my own legacy when it comes to my cricket."

Vivek Krishnan